Mirror to Her Mouth from House Arrest

By Anna Deavere Smith

INTRODUCTION

In 1996, The MacArthur Foundation awarded Anna Deavere Smith a prestigious fellowship, saying she "has created a new form of theatre — a blend of theatrical art, social commentary, journalism and intimate reverie." These words of praise are epitomized by this selection: Mirror to Her Mouth from House Arrest . . . a true story of Paulette Jenkins, whose boyfriend abused her and her daughter. One night the man beat Paulette's daughter so badly that she died. This is Paulette's story as told to Anna Deavere Smith during an interview at the Maryland Correctional Institution for Women and brought to life on stage in Mirror to Her Mouth from House Arrest.

I began to learn how to cover it up

because I didn't want nobody to know that this was happening

In

my home.

Ya know.

I wanted everyone to think that we were a normal family

and I mean

we had all the materialistic things.

But that didn't make my children pain any less.

I ran out of excuses about how we got black eyes

and busted lips and bruises

me and the kids.

I didn't have no more excuses.

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But it didn't change the fact that it was a nightmare

for my children.

It was a nightmare.

And I failed them.

Dramatically.

Because I allowed it to continue on and on and on.

And that night that she got killed,

and the intensity that grew and grew and grew.

Until one night,

we came home,

from getting drugs,

and he got angry with Myeshia

and he started beating her.

And he just continued to beat her,

he had a belt, he would use a belt.

I'm just speaking of the particular night she died.

And he beat her

and he put her in the bathtub.

And I was in the bedroom.

But before all this happened,

four months before she died,

I thought I could really fix this man

so I had a baby by him!

Insane?

Thinking that

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if I gave him his own kid

he'll leave mine alone.

And it didn't work.

We wound up with three children.

But the night that Myeshia died.

I stayed in the room with the baby.

And I heard him,

just beating her,

just beating her,

like I said he had her in the bathtub,

and every time he would hit her,

she would fall.

And she would hit her head on the tub.

I could hear it.

It happened continuously,

repeatedly.

(Whispering.)

And I dared not to move.

I didn't move.

I didn't even go see what was happening.

I just sat there and listened.

And then later

(SHE sucks her teeth.)

he sat her in the hallway

and

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told her just set there

and she set there for 'bout

four to five hours

and then he told her to get up

(Crying.)

and when she got up she said she couldn't see.

(Whispering, crying.)

Her face was bruised.

And she had a black eye.

All around her head was just swollen.

Her head looked like it was two sizes of its own size.

I told him to let her go to sleep and he let her go to sleep.

(Whispering.)

The next morning she was dead.

He went in and checked on her for school.

And he got very excited.

And he said

"She won't breathe!"

I knew immediately that she was dead.

'Cause I went in

I didn't even want to accept the fact that she was dead.

So I went and took a mirror to her mouth.

There

was no-thing coming out of her mouth.

Nothing.

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He said

"We cannot let nobody know about this,

so you got to help me."

And I agreed.

I agreed.

I didn't dare tell anyone.

'Cause I had been keeping it a secret

for years and years.

And it just seemed like secondhand to me

to keep a secret.

That night,

we went to the mall

and we told the police

that she had been missing.

We told like the security guards of the mall

that we had like lost her.

Ya know we fabricated this story and I went along with it.

And we told him that she had been missing.

But she wasn't missing.

So after that

we left the mall

and we told them what she had on

that night.

We got her dressed in the exact same thing

that we told the police that we had put on her.

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And we got the baby

and we drove like out to

(Hear her getting the slightest bit tired here.)

I-95.

I was so petrified

and so numb

all I could look

was in the rearview mirror.

And he just laid her right on the shoulder of the highway.

My own chile.

I let that happen to.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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